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Opportunity or nonsense? Examining the role of CEOs' social media usage in raising funds

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Amid the ongoing digital transformation, social media has emerged as a novel avenue for business communication and growth, with investors increasingly engaging with these platforms as supplementary information sources. However, whether and how CEOs' social media activity influences firms' financing outcomes remains an open and pressing question. This study investigates this relationship by employing regression analysis and Latent Dirichlet Allocation thematic modeling on a sample of 1438 Chinese firms that received their first round of venture financing (Series A) in 2015. The results reveal that CEOs' social media usage is significantly negatively associated with financing outcomes. This correlation is further moderated by the CEOs' regulatory focus, their social capital, and the firms' business model. The study draws on field theory, upper echelons theory, and regulatory focus theory to develop a comprehensive analytical framework, offering new insights into entrepreneurial financing behavior and strategic managerial use of social media in capital-raising contexts.

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Introduction

Riding the wave of digital transformation, social media platforms have emerged as pivotal conduits for business communication and information dissemination. The bidirectional nature of these platforms—where users can freely alternate between consuming and producing content—enhances information symmetry (Jensen, 1986) and improves communication efficiency. Against the backdrop of 5 G commercialization, social media has undergone substantial advancements in both service quality and user adoption, thereby continually empowering businesses. These platforms have facilitated the shift from Business-to-Business (B2B) to Business-to-Consumer (B2C) models, enabling firms to establish more direct and immediate connections with end consumers. This transition has not only fostered new business models but has also reshaped interactions between consumers and brands, influencing corporate marketing strategies, brand management, and consumer behavior (Lim, 2023; So et al. 2024; Cooper et al. 2023; Macca et al. 2024). Moreover, social media has altered the informational dynamics of capital markets and influenced the behavior of key participants. In particular, politicians and business leaders have increasingly recognized the strategic significance of managing their personal social media accounts. Firms, acknowledging the potential of these platforms for targeted stakeholder engagement, are increasingly adopting social media as a strategic communication tool. In addition to its marketing and branding applications, prior research has examined how corporate social media usage influences internal management practices, including employee engagement (Song et al. 2019) and operational efficiency (Hoang et al. 2023).

It is evident that social media, as an emerging information dissemination channel, has had a significant impact on firms, and its utility has traditionally been assessed from the consumer-oriented perspective. However, its utility has traditionally been examined from a consumer-oriented perspective. From an investor's standpoint, social media may also influence firm valuation through mechanisms, such as brand reputation enhancement, direct access to consumer feedback, real-time monitoring of market sentiment (Tumasjan et al. 2021), and the early identification of firm-specific risks and opportunities. These functions are particularly salient for firms that lack historical financial data, making traditional valuation approaches less informative (Aldrich and Fiol, 1994). As a result, many investors turn to firms' social media presence as an alternative communication channel to inform their decisions. For example, Boxtera—a start-up providing healthy food packaging—used Twitter to secure funding from Vandaele Capital LLC. Despite such anecdotal evidence, the academic literature presents mixed findings on the relationship between social media usage and financing performance. Some studies suggest that social media activity enhances firm performance (Bai and Yan, 2023; Ali Qureshi, 2024), and Rakowski et al. (2021) find that retail investor behavior is shaped by content shared on Twitter. However, other studies have failed to detect a statistically significant association between social media usage and financing outcomes (Lin et al. 2022).

The study most closely aligned with this paper's research question is Jin et al. (2017), which finds that launching and maintaining an official corporate social media presence increases the likelihood of successful fundraising by reducing search costs and providing supplementary information to investors. However, firms may use their official social media accounts for impression management, crafting idealized portrayals to influence stakeholders (Suryani and Fernando, 2023). As a result, investors who rely solely on official accounts may form biased perceptions of firm value. Thus, it is essential to investigate how social media can be used more effectively to assess firm quality.

Addressing this gap, Elliott et al. (2018) offer relevant insights for executives considering the costs and benefits of communicating with investors via Twitter. Their experimental findings show that investors are more likely to trust a CEO and invest in a firm when negative earnings news is disclosed through the CEO's personal Twitter account rather than through the firm's official website or social media account. Feng and Johansson (2019) describe CEOs who actively engage on social media as "social executives" and find that firms led by such CEOs tend to have larger investor bases, higher stock liquidity, and greater informational content in their stock prices.

Building on these findings and drawing on upper echelons theory, this study posits that CEOs, as central figures within top management teams, possess individual decision-making styles and behavioral tendencies that shape corporate strategy. CEOs' social media activity may signal their leadership style and strategic direction to market participants, thereby influencing firm reputation and investor perceptions. Accordingly, this study addresses two key research questions:

(1) How does CEO's social media usage influence corporate financing performance?
(2) What are the boundary conditions that influence this relationship?

To investigate these questions, the study analyzes a sample of 1438 Chinese firms that received their first round of funding (Series A) in 2015. It collects CEO-level social media data from Sina Weibo and constructs a theoretical framework linking CEO's social media usage to corporate financing performance, informed by upper echelons theory and field theory. Additionally, the study examines moderating factors based on regulatory focus theory and incorporates social capital and business model characteristics to explore the boundary conditions of the primary relationship.

Empirical findings suggest that CEO's social media usage is negatively associated with financing outcomes, likely due to the entertainment-oriented nature of social media platforms. However, this negative correlation is attenuated for promotion-focused CEOs who are more likely to leverage social media to identify opportunities and enhance firm visibility. Moreover, CEOs with a greater number of followers tend to post more positively framed content, further weakening the negative association. The correlation is also less pronounced for CEOs of firms targeting individual consumers, where direct engagement via social media is more aligned with strategic goals.

This study makes both theoretical and practical contributions. Theoretically, it extends the social media literature by shifting focus from firm-level accounts to the underexplored domain of CEO-level social media behavior. It also reinforces the applicability of upper echelons theory and introduces regulatory focus theory into the discussion of CEO communication strategies and financing outcomes. Practically, the findings offer strategic insights for firms seeking to optimize executive social media usage and provide investors with cautionary guidance in interpreting social media cues when evaluating early-stage firms.

The remainder of the paper is structured as follows: Section 2 discusses the theoretical background and hypothesis development. Section 3 outlines data collection, variable measurement, and model construction. Section 4 presents robustness checks, followed by additional empirical analysis in Section 5. Sections 6 and 7 conclude with a summary of findings, research contributions, and future research directions.

Theoretical background and hypotheses

Theoretical background. Numerous management scholars have examined how the characteristics of top executives influence firm

performance. To consolidate previously fragmented research, Hambrick and Mason (1984) introduced a general "upper-level perspective" and developed a corresponding model. Specifically, upper echelons theory posits that "organizational outcomes—strategic choices and performance levels—are partially predicted by managerial background characteristics" (Hambrick and Mason, 1984, p. 193). This theory has been widely applied to explain how CEO traits influence a range of organizational outcomes. For example, scholars drawing on this framework have shown that CEO attributes are positively associated with firm performance, particularly in areas such as capital investment decisions (Liu et al. 2018; Ali et al. 2022). In sum, a CEO's characteristics shape strategic goals and decision-making processes, which are especially consequential for ventures seeking external financing.

Upper echelons theory provides a relevant lens through which to explore the present study's research question: how does CEO's social media usage influence corporate financing performance? Within the theoretical framework, the CEO, as a central member of the top management team, plays a decisive role in formulating and implementing the firm's strategy through individual cognitive styles and behavioral patterns. CEOs' social media activities, representing an extension of their personal and professional identity, increasingly form a critical component of the firm's broader communication strategy. Given the public and interactive nature of social media platforms, CEOs' online presence can quickly disseminate to diverse audiences, shaping initial perceptions of the firm's governance quality, transparency, and innovative posture.

Whether sharing professional insights or aspects of their personal lives, CEOs communicate signals that can influence how investors and other stakeholders interpret the firm's leadership style and strategic direction. These interpretations, in turn, may predict perceptions of corporate reputation and investor relations. Owing to the immediacy and broad reach of digital platforms, these impressions can rapidly shape market sentiment. Accordingly, understanding the relationship between CEO's social media behavior and financing performance constitutes a meaningful academic inquiry. Social media usage may influence financing cost, access to capital, and the structure of funding by shaping investor risk perceptions, trust, and expectations. However, the precise mechanisms by which this occurs remain underexplored and require empirical validation. From a theoretical standpoint, upper echelons theory offers a plausible foundation for predicting an association between CEO's social media behavior and financing outcomes, as it links top executives' observable characteristics to organizational decision-making and performance.

This study employs social media usage as a proxy for CEO attributes. Social media, recognized as both an information technology (IT) tool and a strategic communication mechanism, plays a prominent role in contemporary business strategy and marketing (Jaman et al. 2020). It facilitates two-way communication with customers and supports the development of personalized messaging and brand-building initiatives (Infante and Mardikaningsih, 2022; Abell and Biswas, 2023). Social media thus represents one of the most transformative IT developments impacting organizations across internal and external boundaries. Moreover, researchers have demonstrated that text data extracted from social media can effectively reflect individual personality traits (Wang and Chen, 2020; Farnadi et al. 2016). For instance, Azucar et al. (2018) show that lexicon-based approaches can accurately infer personality profiles, while Adamopoulos et al. (2018) demonstrate that unstructured social media data can be processed using data mining algorithms to capture individual characteristics.

Hypotheses development

CEO's social media usage and corporate financing performance. Field theory conceptualizes society as a complex structure composed of distinct fields—social arenas governed by their own logic, norms, and power dynamics (Bourdieu, 1991). Each human action is shaped by the field in which it occurs, which extends beyond physical environments to include the behaviors of others and the broader sociocultural context. Field theory has increasingly been adopted as an analytical framework to explain individual and organizational behaviors on social media platforms (Shang et al. 2017; Joshi et al. 2023).

In the present context, CEOs' presence on social media constitutes a field involving multiple participants—such as firms, investors, and platforms—interacting within a network of overlapping social dynamics. According to Bourdieu's framework, the relationship between CEO's social media usage and corporate financing performance is shaped by the tensions that arise between the norms of the social media field and those of the financial and corporate fields. The essence of the social media field is the attention economy, the rules of which are shaped by platform algorithms, user behavior, and cultural trends. Take Sina Weibo as an example, its content ecology is oriented to "pan-entertainment" - users prefer fragmented and emotional expression, and the platform algorithm gives priority to recommending highly interactive content (e.g., celebrity gossip, hot stories), forming an informal, entertainment-oriented field logic. In contrast, commercial and financial fields follow the logic of capital appreciation, relying on professional symbols (e.g., financial statements, compliance disclosures) and institutional trust (e.g., audit reports, institutional ratings), emphasizing information rigor and risk aversion. When a CEO's online behavior deviates from these norms—for example, by appearing overly casual or self-promotional—it may undermine the perception of managerial credibility and weaken trust in the firm's governance.

This potential misalignment may negatively influence investor perceptions and increase the perceived risk associated with financing the firm. For instance, research suggests that individuals who frequently post personal photos on social media are often perceived as high in neuroticism (Pflügner et al. 2021), a trait not typically associated with executive leadership. Such cues may distort the firm's image in the eyes of capital market participants.

Moreover, the symbolic capital that CEOs accumulate on social media—such as visibility, popularity, and social influence—must be transformed into economic capital, such as improved financing outcomes. Field theory emphasizes that this capital transformation is not automatic but context-dependent. In business and financial fields, economic capital and professional achievements are prioritized over social visibility. When symbolic capital is misaligned with these values, the transformation process may be disrupted, resulting in unintended negative effects.

Additionally, fields differ in their behavioral and cultural expectations. CEO's social media expressions that are incongruent with corporate culture or industry norms may send ambiguous or conflicting signals to the market. This inconsistency may diminish investor confidence in the firm's strategic direction, thereby increasing information asymmetry and financing costs.

Based on these arguments, the study proposes the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1: CEO's social media usage has a negative influence on corporate financing performance.

The moderating role of CEOs' regulatory focus. Regulatory focus theory posits that individuals' goal-directed behaviors are guided by two distinct motivational systems: (a) a promotion focus, which is oriented toward achieving gains and advancement, and (b) a

prevention focus, which centers on maintaining the status quo and avoiding losses (Higgins, 1998). Specifically, individuals with a high promotion focus are motivated by aspirations for growth and success, whereas those with a high prevention focus are motivated by safety, responsibility, and the desire to avoid negative outcomes.

Prior studies confirm that promotion and prevention foci function as independent regulatory systems rather than two poles of a single continuum. These differences in regulatory focus lead to distinct behavioral patterns and performance outcomes. For example, promotion-focused job crafting has been shown to enhance employee performance, while prevention-focused job crafting is often negatively associated with outcomes (Lichtenthaler and Fischbach, 2019). In the context of executive decision-making, research has demonstrated that CEOs' regulatory focus influences corporate outcomes such as innovation strategy (Glaveli et al. 2023), cross-border acquisitions (Gada et al. 2024), and international expansion (Biru et al. 2023). Moreover, the effects of regulatory focus on managerial decision-making are highly context-dependent (Hoskisson et al. 2023).

Regulatory focus theory, therefore, provides a valuable lens through which to analyze how CEO regulatory focus moderates the relationship between social media usage and financing performance. CEOs with a prevention focus are more likely to adopt cautious communication strategies, emphasizing risk mitigation and status preservation. As a result, they may be reluctant to use social media proactively or may limit their engagement to risk-averse content. In contrast, promotion-focused CEOs tend to view social media as a strategic tool to highlight corporate achievements, articulate visions for growth, and build a forward-looking brand narrative.

By sharing success stories, business milestones, and innovation efforts, promotion-focused CEOs can reduce uncertainty, foster investor confidence, and positively shape market perceptions. In addition, their greater transparency and openness in communication may reduce information asymmetry and lower perceived investment risk, ultimately leading to lower financing costs. Positive engagement through social media may also strengthen brand identity and stakeholder trust.

Building on theoretical foundations and empirical research (Gamache et al. 2015), this study identifies CEO regulatory focus based on the frequency and content of social media posts. CEOs with a promotion focus are expected to post more frequently and with a greater emphasis on business-related content, while prevention-focused CEOs are expected to post less frequently and with less strategic relevance. Therefore, it is anticipated that the negative impact of social media usage on corporate financing performance may be attenuated—or even reversed—among promotion-focused CEOs.

Hypothesis 2: The negative influence of CEOs' social media usage on corporate financing performance is attenuated for CEOs with a promotion focus.

The moderating role of social capital. Prior research suggests that self-presentation is a key motivator for CEOs' use of social media (Men and Tsai, 2016). Self-presentation refers to the strategic use of behavior to convey information about one's identity and personality to others (Goffman, 1959; Baumeister, 1982). Social interaction—particularly through digital platforms—creates opportunities for individuals to manage impressions and shape how they are perceived. For entrepreneurs and executives, social media serves as a unique venue to showcase their values, leadership style, and brand identity (Aslam et al. 2024). Wang et al. (2020) argue that self-presentation aligns with entrepreneurs' goal of crafting a favorable personal brand. To achieve this, they commonly use persuasive language, visuals, storytelling, and brand positioning strategies (Hussain et al. 2021). In the context of Weibo, Alghawi et al. (2014) identify four CEO self-presentation strategies: the expert strategy, friend strategy, textbook strategy, and diary strategy.

Interestingly, the extent and style of self-presentation on social media are shaped not only by platform norms but also by the size and strength of one's audience (Zheng et al. 2020; Van De Velde et al. 2015). When sharing content with a broader audience, individuals tend to avoid negative disclosures and engage in more strategically curated self-presentation (Oh et al. 2023). Studies also show that a company's social media presence positively influences its stock price, but only when CEOs' accounts reach a critical mass of followers (Paniagua and Sapena, 2014). CEOs with a larger and more engaged follower base are more likely to practice positive self-presentation and enhance their firm's perceived legitimacy and trustworthiness. This enhanced image can reduce financing frictions and positively influence fundraising outcomes.

Given the growing importance of social media in corporate communication—and CEOs' symbolic role in shaping firm image—the current study uses follower count as a proxy for CEO social capital. This measure captures the size of CEOs' digital networks and reflects their influence and credibility in the online sphere. CEOs' followers may include not only customers, but also investors, industry peers, analysts, and other stakeholders. Collectively, this social capital contributes to the firm's intangible assets and can enhance its signaling capacity in capital markets. Therefore, the study proposes the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 3: The negative influence of CEOs' social media usage on corporate financing performance is attenuated as the number of followers increases.

The moderating role of business model. This study defines business models based on the type of customer served—B2B, B2C, or hybrid. These categories capture whether a firm's primary stakeholders are organizations, individuals, or both. Existing literature highlights important differences in how B2B and B2C firms adopt and use social media. Specifically, social media is more integral to communication strategies in B2C firms compared to B2B firms (Iankova et al. 2019). In B2B contexts, companies often lack comprehensive digital marketing strategies, and stakeholders generally perceive social media as less effective for relationship-building (Agnihotri and John-Mariadoss, 2022; Agnihotri et al. 2023).

Conversely, B2C firms operate in markets where stakeholders are more dispersed and demand greater transparency. In such environments, social media serves as a powerful tool for communicating corporate values, sharing strategic updates, and fostering customer engagement. B2C firms tend to be more advanced in social media marketing, often integrating platforms like Facebook, Twitter, and LinkedIn into their customer relationship strategies (Lamberton and Stephen, 2016; Siamagka et al. 2015). As a result, the public communication of CEOs in B2C firms is more likely to align with organizational goals and stakeholder expectations, thereby mitigating the potentially negative correlations of personal social media usage.

Given these differences, the study posits that CEOs' social media usage may be more positively received—or at least less negatively interpreted—within B2C firms. Accordingly, the following hypothesis is proposed:

Hypothesis 4: The negative influence of CEOs' social media usage on corporate financing performance is attenuated for firms with B2C business models.

The study constructs a conceptual model as shown in Fig. 1.

Method

Data collection. This study investigates a sample of 1438 Chinese companies that secured their initial round of external financing

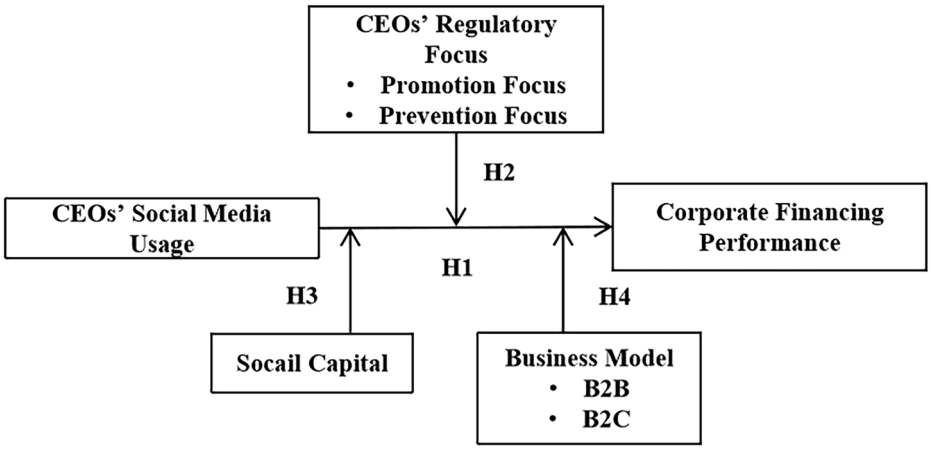


Fig. 1 Conceptual Framework.

(Series A) in 2015. Social media usage data for the CEOs of these firms were collected from Sina Weibo, with authorized access, alongside comprehensive financing data.

China presents an ideal context for this study for several reasons. First, as an emerging market, it has attracted considerable global investment interest. Unlike developed Western economies, China's financial system is still in a growth stage, paralleling the expansion of its internet infrastructure. This synchronicity enhances the relevance and timeliness of studying the intersection of digital communication and capital markets in the region. Second, China represents the world's largest social media market, characterized by a vast user base and a highly engaged online population.

The year 2015 is particularly significant. In that year, the Chinese government launched major policy initiatives to encourage mass entrepreneurship and innovation, creating a favorable environment for business formation and expansion. Furthermore, starting in 2016, the Sino-U.S. trade war introduced market volatility and increased uncertainty. Accordingly, firms that received Series A funding in 2015 are viewed as representative cases for examining the impact of CEO communication in an environment of economic dynamism and digital growth.

Sina Weibo is selected as the primary platform for data collection. As a public, relationship-based microblogging service, it facilitates real-time content dissemination through a follow-based mechanism. Its open structure enhances message visibility and provides greater information transparency compared to private social platforms. Under the lens of big data analytics, Weibo's public nature supports the authenticity and traceability of CEO communications. Moreover, the platform's sustained influence underscores its relevance: by 2023, it had reached 598 million monthly active users and 257 million daily active users, highlighting its validity as a data source for research into executive online behavior.

A flowchart outlining the steps involved in the empirical analysis is provided in Fig. 2.

Measures

Dependent variable. $Fund_i$ Following prior literature (Jin et al. 2017), this study focuses on firms' ability to secure second-round financing (Series B) as the dependent variable. This approach is adopted for two main reasons. First, not all firms seek venture capital funding beyond the initial round, and therefore, using first-round data may introduce noise, as it does not capture firms' financing intentions consistently. By restricting the sample to firms that have already completed Series A financing, the study ensures that these firms are actively engaged in external fundraising. Second, social media serves as an information channel that investors often use in the early stages of firm evaluation. Since firms typically become more established and IPO-ready after the second funding round, the effect of CEOs' social media usage is expected to be most pronounced at this stage. The dependent variable is binary: 1 if the firm successfully obtained Series B financing, and 0 otherwise.

Independent variable. $Weibo_i$ The independent variable is $Weibo_i$, a binary indicator equal to 1 if the CEO maintains a personal Sina Weibo account, and 0 otherwise. This variable captures CEOs' social media presence.

Moderating variable. $LDAF_i$ CEOs with a promotion focus tend to post business-related content more frequently, while prevention-focused CEOs either post infrequently or focus on non-business content. To capture this, the study collects the full corpus of each CEO's Weibo posts. Non-informative elements (e.g., punctuation, English letters, stop words) are removed, and the text is segmented into words. Only posts from CEOs' personal Weibo accounts are used, consistent with research suggesting that social media enables more unfiltered self-expression than formal speeches or interviews (Wang and Chen, 2020). Using Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA), the study identifies dominant topics for each post, classifying them as business- or non-business-related. Posts are assigned a business topic label if their business-topic probability exceeds 0.8. $LDAF_i$ is defined as the proportion of each CEO's posts that relate to business. For CEOs with minimal posting activity, $LDAF_i$ is coded as 0.

$KeyF_i$ CEOs with a promotion focus are also more likely to directly reference their companies in posts. Using the same preprocessed text data, $KeyF_i$ is calculated as the proportion of business-related keywords (e.g., company name, primary business operations) relative to total words posted by the CEO. As with $LDAF_i$, CEOs with few or no posts are assigned a value of 0 for $KeyF_i$.

$InorOr_i$ This binary variable captures the firm's business model: $InorOr_i = 1$ if the firm operates in a B2C model and 0 if in a B2B model.

$Follow_i$ This is the number of followers on CEOs' Sina Weibo accounts, serving as a proxy for the CEOs' social capital. To address potential skewness and reduce the influence of outliers, this variable is winsorized at the 1st and 99th percentiles and log-transformed.

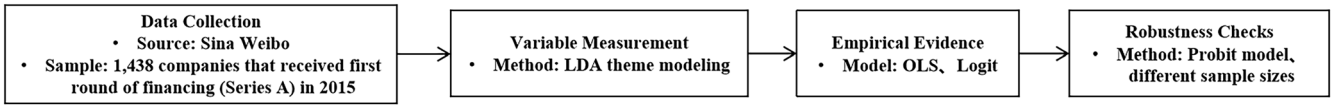


Fig. 2 Flowchart of the Analysis Process.

Table 1 Descriptive Statistics.

Variables	Mean	SD	Skewness	Kurtosis	p25	p50	p75
Fund	0.519	0.500	−0.077	1.006	0	1	1
Weibo	0.059	0.235	3.755	15.100	0	0	0
GDP	10.400	0.550	−0.195	4.652	10.040	10.130	11.160
Ft	2011	4.078	−1.646	5.742	2010	2012	2014
Vestors	1.639	1.128	2.965	16.650	1	1	2
Bg	0.970	0.470	−0.753	54.837	1	1	1
Ex	0.160	0.490	1.807	1.269	0	0	0
CEOSe	0.810	0.390	−1.634	0.672	1	1	1
LDAF	0.462	0.147	0.423	3.431	0.367	0.454	0.546
KeyF	0.053	0.030	−0.080	2.080	0.033	0.050	0.080
InorOr	0.655	0.478	−0.651	1.424	0	1	1
Follow	8654	10,303	1.154	2.667	1507	3372	11,775

Table 2 Sub-sample Summary Statistics.

	CEOs with a Weibo account				CEOs without a Weibo account			
Variables	Mean	SD	Min	Max	Mean	SD	Min	Max
Fund	0.393	0.491	0	1	0.527	0.499	0	1
GDP	10.410	0.555	6.934	11.260	10.320	0.455	9.713	11.200
Ft	2011	4.146	1990	2018	2012	2.417	2003	2017
Vestors	1.631	1.131	1	10	1.774	1.079	1	6
Bg	0.870	0.130	0	1	0.980	0.130	0	1
Ex	0.160	0.370	0	1	0.150	0.360	0	1
CEOSe	0.810	0.380	0	1	0.800	0.400	0	1

Control variables. To account for alternative explanations, the following control variables are included:

GDP_i The natural logarithm of the gross domestic product of the firm's registered province, reflecting the level of regional economic development (Karkinsky and Riedel, 2012).

Ft_i The year the firm was founded, capturing firm age (Zhao et al. 2022).

$Vestor_i$ The number of investors associated with the firm (Guidry and Patten, 2012).

Bg_i A binary variable indicating CEOs' cultural background; 1 if Chinese, 0 otherwise (Boone et al. 2019).

Ex_i Equals 1 if the CEO has previously served as CEO of another company; 0 otherwise (Custódio and Metzger, 2014).

$CEOSe_i$ Equals 1 if the CEO is not a member of the board of directors (i.e., separation of roles), and 0 otherwise (Wang and Chen, 2020).

The selection of control variables is grounded in relevant theory and prior empirical research. For example, GDP captures macroeconomic variation, while firm age, investor count, and CEO background characteristics are well-documented determinants of financing outcomes. However, the study acknowledges the possibility of omitted variables, such as internal governance quality or market fluctuations. Future research is encouraged to explore these dimensions further.

Table 1 presents descriptive statistics for the key variables. Approximately 52% of firms in the sample obtained second-round financing. The mean value of $Weibo_i$ is 0.059, with a standard deviation of 0.235 and a skewness of 3.755. The average provincial GDP (log-transformed) is 10.400. On average, the firms were founded in 2011. The mean number of investors is 1.639 (SD = 1.128), and the average proportion of business-related keywords in CEO posts is 0.053.

Table 2 is the summary statistics of our independent and control variables by Weibo across the sub-samples. The results suggest that CEOs with Weibo accounts may have a negative influence on corporate fundraising. In this category, when CEOs had Weibo accounts, the mean of Fund was 0.393, and 0.527 on the other side. For the other control variables, the difference between the two categories of statistical indicators is not significant.

Models. In exploring the influence of CEOs' social media usage on corporate finance performance, the study begins by using OLS as a starting point for our analysis.The advantage of the OLS model lies in its simplicity and intuition, which can quickly reveal the linear relationship between variables and help us to understand the basic structure of the data, as shown in Eq. (1).

$$Fund_i = \beta_1 weibo + \beta_2 Controls + \varepsilon, \quad (1)$$

The study then introduces Logit models to deepen the analysis. Given that financing performance is a binary variable (whether or not a second round of financing is secured), the Logit model provides a more precise analytical framework. Compared to OLS, Logit models can deal with the inherent characteristics of binary data, capture non-linear relationships, and interpret model outputs as probabilities, taking into account the potential impact

of other variables. As shown in Eq. (2).

$$\text{Fund} = \frac{\exp(U_i)}{1+\exp(U_i)}$$
$$U_i = \beta_1 weibo + Controls + \varepsilon, \quad (2)$$

where *Controls* represent all the controls (i.e., GDP, Ft, and Vestors). Thus, the coefficient we are interested in is β_1, that represents the influence of CEOs' Weibo usage on funding outcome. To detect the heterogeneous impact, introduce interaction terms as in specification (3).

$$Fund_i = \beta_1 weibo + \beta_2 weibo * Interactionterm + Controls + \varepsilon, \quad (3)$$

where *Interactionterm* indicates the moderators we test, including $LDAF_i$, which is the frequency of each CEO's posts related to business to the total number of posts, and $KeyF_i$, which is the proportion of words related to company business in Weibo published by the CEO.

Results. Table 3 presents our main results. As expected, CEOs' use of Weibo will have a negative influence on the company's next round of funding ($\beta = -0.117, p < 0.01$). The results in the column 2 of Table 3 also demonstrate the robustness of the results. This supports Hypothesis 1.

To explore the heterogeneous effects, the study conducts regression analysis, and the results are presented in Table 4. The study finds that the more CEOs post on Weibo related to their company's business, the more likely the company is to secure second-round funding ($\beta = 4.820, p < 0.01$). In column 3 of Table 4, it is observed that the more CEOs mention keywords related to their company's business in their Weibo posts, the more likely the company is to obtain second-round funding ($\beta = 21.124, p < 0.05$). This suggests that the negative influence is attenuated and even becomes positive and significant for CEOs with a promotion focus. This supports Hypothesis 2.

Table 3 The Influence of Social Media on Financing Outcome in Logit Model.

	Fund	Logit (Fund)
Weibo	−0.117** (0.056)	−0.508** (0.241)
GDP	0.021 (0.024)	0.086 (0.101)
Ft	−0.010*** (0.003)	−0.041*** (0.014)
Vestors	0.055*** (0.012)	0.270*** (0.057)
Bg	−0.378*** (0.105)	−2.903*** (1.033)
Ex	0.039 (0.036)	0.160 (0.152)
CEOSe	−0.128*** (0.035)	−0.539*** (0.148)
observations	1438	1438
R-Squared/log-likelihood	0.038	−967.323

Standard errors in parentheses, ***$p < 0.01$, **$p < 0.05$, *$p < 0.1$.

Robustness checks

To further test the relationship between CEO's social media usage and financing performance, the study employs a model analysis and examines various sample sizes (Neumayer and Plümper, 2017). The robustness of the findings is confirmed.

Probit model analysis. The logistic model is a popular model based on the logistic probability distribution of error terms, and its results are easy to interpret. Another model of error distribution is the Probit model, which relies on the normal distribution of error terms (Oezpolat et al. 2013). The results of the probit model are reported in Table 5. The study finds that CEOs' presence on Sina Weibo negatively influences the company's fundraising process ($\beta = -0.309, p < 0.05$). But CEO with a promotion focus mitigated the negative influence. This confirms the robustness of our conclusions.

Analysis of different sample sizes. To further test the robustness of the findings, the study conducts an additional analysis by excluding companies from heavy industries—such as fiber optics and petrochemicals—that tend to place less strategic emphasis on social media. These firms may have limited digital engagement due to the nature of their operations, which could confound the observed relationship between CEOs' social media usage and financing outcomes.

After excluding these firms, the empirical results remain robust, as presented in Table 6. Specifically, CEO presence on Sina Weibo continues to be negatively associated with second-round financing outcomes ($\beta = -0.628, p < 0.05$). Furthermore, the moderating effect of promotion-focused CEOs persists, mitigating the negative association between CEOs' social media usage and fundraising performance. These findings reinforce the study's primary conclusions.

It is important to acknowledge the trade-offs associated with excluding industry subgroups. On the one hand, the removal of heavy industry firms reduces sample heterogeneity and may limit the generalizability of the results across all sectors. On the other hand, this refinement allows the study to focus on firms for which social media plays a more central role in external communication and investor signaling. By narrowing the sample, the study enhances internal validity and strengthens the interpretability of the social media effect within relevant industry contexts.

The results of the robustness checks demonstrate that the primary findings remain consistent across different model

Table 4 The Heterogeneous Impact of CEOs in Logit Model.

	Logit (Fund)	Logit (Fund)	Logit (Fund)
Weibo	−0.508** (0.241)	−2.769*** (0.890)	−1.668*** (0.550)
GDP	0.086 (0.101)	0.084 (0.101)	0.074 (0.101)
Ft	−0.041*** (0.014)	−0.042*** (0.014)	−0.040*** (0.014)
Vestors	0.270*** (0.057)	0.269*** (0.058)	0.263*** (0.057)
Bg	−2.903*** (1.033)	−2.943*** (1.035)	−3.013*** (1.046)
Ex	0.160 (0.152)	0.165 (0.152)	0.151 (0.152)
CEOSe	−0.539*** (0.148)	−0.541*** (0.148)	−0.542*** (0.148)
Weibo × LDAF		4.820*** (1.798)	
Weibo ×KeyF			21.124** (8.633)
observations	1438	1438	1438
Log likelihood	−967.323	−960.205	−961.27

Standard errors in parentheses, ***$p < 0.01$, **$p < 0.05$, *$p < 0.1$.

Table 5 Robustness Checks—The Heterogeneous Impact of CEOs in Probit Model.

	Probit (Fund)	Probit (Fund)	Probit (Fund)
Weibo	−0.309** (0.148)	−1.697*** (0.528)	−0.990*** (0.315)
GDP	0.057 (0.062)	0.056 (0.063)	0.050 (0.063)
Ft	−0.025*** (0.009)	−0.026*** (0.009)	−0.025*** (0.009)
Vestors	0.160*** (0.033)	0.159*** (0.033)	0.156*** (0.033)
Bg	−1.637*** (0.488)	−1.655*** (0.489)	−1.679*** (0.492)
Ex	0.099 (0.094)	0.101 (0.094)	0.093 (0.094)
CEOSe	−0.339*** (0.091)	−0.340*** (0.091)	−0.341*** (0.091)
Weibo × LDAF		2.972*** (1.084)	
Weibo × KeyF			12.598** (5.062)
observations	1438	1438	1438
Log likelihood	−967.915	−960.663	−961.765

Standard errors in parentheses, ***$p < 0.01$, **$p < 0.05$, *$p < 0.1$.

Table 6 Robustness Checks—The Heterogeneous Impact of CEOs in Logit Model.

	Logit (Fund)	Logit (Fund)	Logit (Fund)
Weibo	−0.628** (0.261)	−2.376*** (0.912)	−1.883*** (0.611)
GDP	0.070 (0.105)	0.068 (0.105)	0.057 (0.105)
Ft	−0.050*** (0.015)	−0.051*** (0.015)	−0.050*** (0.015)
Vestors	0.280*** (0.060)	0.281*** (0.061)	0.274*** (0.060)
Bg	−2.929*** (1.034)	−2.955*** (1.035)	−3.064*** (1.053)
Ex	0.146 (0.158)	0.151 (0.159)	0.146 (0.159)
CEOSe	−0.482*** (0.154)	−0.484*** (0.154)	−0.486*** (0.154)
Weibo × LDAF		3.745** (1.842)	
Weibo × KeyF			22.617** (9.465)
Observations	1282	1282	1282
Log likelihood	−861.908	−857.980	−859.119

Standard errors in parentheses, ***$p < 0.01$, **$p < 0.05$, *$p < 0.1$.

specifications and sample sizes. Model fit is evaluated using log-likelihood values for both the Probit and Logit estimations. In the Probit model, the log-likelihood values across robustness specifications are reported as –967.915, –960.663, and –961.765, respectively. Corresponding values for the Logit model are –967.323, –960.205, and –961.270, respectively.

Both Probit and Logit models are widely used in the analysis of binary outcomes; however, they differ in their underlying assumptions. The Logit model assumes a logistic distribution of the error term, while the Probit model assumes a standard normal distribution. Although these models typically yield similar estimates, they may vary in their sensitivity to outliers and the precision of estimated coefficients.

In this study, minor variations in log-likelihood values are observed between the two models. However, these differences are not statistically significant, suggesting that both specifications perform similarly in terms of model fit. Notably, while the Probit model may be more sensitive to extreme values, any discrepancies in coefficient estimates between the Probit and Logit models do not affect the overall interpretation of the results.

Across both model types, the central finding remains robust: CEOs' social media usage is negatively associated with second-round financing outcomes. Moreover, the moderating role of CEO promotion focus is consistently supported—mitigating the adverse effect of social media usage on financing performance. These results strengthen the empirical validity of the study's theoretical framework.

Empirical extension

To further explore the moderating mechanisms proposed in Hypotheses 3 and 4, the study conducts additional regression analyses. Hypothesis 3 examines whether CEO social capital—measured by the number of followers on CEOs' Sina Weibo accounts—mitigates the negative influence of CEOs' social media usage on corporate financing performance. The results, presented in Column 1 of Table 7, show that follower count is positively associated with the likelihood of obtaining second-round financing ($\beta = 0.001, p < 0.05$). This finding suggests that CEOs with a larger social media following are more effective in using social media as a communication and signaling tool, thereby attenuating the negative impact observed in the baseline analysis. The result supports Hypothesis 3.

The study also tests Hypothesis 4 by examining whether the firm's business model moderates the relationship between CEOs' social media usage and financing outcomes. As shown in Column 2 of Table 7, the coefficient for the interaction term between CEOs' social media presence and a B2C model is positive and statistically significant ($\beta = 1.348, p < 0.05$). This indicates that the negative influence of CEOs' social media usage is reduced in B2C firms, where public communication is more aligned with customer and stakeholder expectations. This result provides empirical support for Hypothesis 4.

To further contextualize the main findings, the study applies LDA topic modeling to analyze the thematic content of CEOs' Weibo posts. As presented in Table 8, four distinct themes emerge: daily life, alcohol, lifestyle, and entertainment, and business. Among these, only Theme 4 pertains to business-related content. This supports the notion that much of the content on Sina Weibo is personal or entertainment-driven rather than professional in nature.

These findings align with external evidence on the platform's user demographics and content trends. According to the *Weibo User Development Report 2020*, approximately 80% of users

belong to the post-90s and post-00s generations, indicating a predominantly youthful user base. These users tend to engage with topics such as movies, TV series, and games—further reinforcing the platform's "pan-entertainment" orientation. Similarly, data from the *China Social Application User Behavior Research Report* by the China Internet Network Information Center shows that 60.7% of Weibo users rely on the platform to follow trending news and entertainment content.

Collectively, these findings underscore the entertainment-centric nature of Sina Weibo and help explain the disconnect between CEOs' social media activity and investor expectations. From the perspective of field theory, the informal, entertainment-oriented characteristics of the social media field may conflict with the formal norms and professional standards of the financial and corporate fields. This misalignment helps account for the observed negative association between CEOs' social media usage and financing outcomes in the main analysis.

Discussions

Results discussion. The study's findings align closely with the previously proposed hypotheses. The analysis reveals that CEOs' social media usage negatively impacts the likelihood of obtaining the next round of financing, consistent with Hypothesis 1. However, this negative correlation is mitigated when the CEO possesses a promotion focus, has a larger number of followers, and when the company operates within a B2C business model, as outlined in Hypotheses 2, 3, and 4.

These results contrast with the conclusions drawn by Jin et al. (2017), and we attribute this divergence to two main factors. First, the social media platforms analyzed differ significantly. While Jin et al. used Twitter, our study focuses on Sina Weibo, which differs not only in functionality but also in user demographics and geographical reach. Twitter is predominantly text-based and has a wider international influence, whereas Sina Weibo is more multimedia-oriented and primarily popular in China. Moreover, differences in content censorship and government control between the platforms could also influence user behavior and information dissemination. Second, the data sets differ in scope: Jin et al. primarily studied technology firms, while our sample is not industry-restricted, which may influence the findings.

To explain why the negative impact of CEOs' social media usage is attenuated in certain cases, we focus on the common characteristics of the three moderating variables: social media as a two-way communication channel and its ability to generate immediate feedback. These attributes align with consumer preferences, suggesting that CEOs' social media usage can be a valuable tool for marketing and brand-building.

However, the question remains: why does CEOs' social media usage have differing impacts on sales versus financing outcomes? For sales, social media serves as a direct channel to connect with consumers, facilitating emotional engagement through CEOs' personal stories or brand messaging. This can foster impulse purchasing behaviors and value co-creation (Bao et al. 2023; Rashid et al. 2019), building psychological proximity between consumers and the brand (Furukawa, 2022; Yue et al. 2021). By contrast, investment decisions are typically rational, motivated by profit maximization and risk assessment, and therefore investors are more concerned with the professionalism, growth potential, and financial health of the firm. While CEOs' strategic vision is important to investors, presenting this effectively through social media is challenging. Under the pan-entertainment attributes of social media, CEO activity may be perceived as inconsistent with the professional standards expected in financial decision-making. Thus, while moderation factors help mitigate the negative influence, they do not fully satisfy investors' decision-making criteria.

Table 7 Empirical Extension Results in Logit Model.

	Logit (Fund)	Logit (Fund)
Weibo	−0.577** (0.280)	−1.457*** (0.490)
GDP	0.088 (0.101)	0.083 (0.101)
Ft	−0.041*** (0.014)	−0.041*** (0.014)
Vestors	0.268*** (0.057)	0.265*** (0.057)
Bg	−2.909*** (1.033)	−2.971*** (1.037)
Ex	0.162 (0.152)	0.156 (0.152)
CEOSe	−0.539*** (0.148)	−0.536*** (0.148)
Weibo × Follow	0.001*** (0.000)	
Weibo × InorOr		1.348** (0.557)
Observations	1438	1438
Log likelihood	−961.07	−961.92

Standard errors in parentheses, ***$p < 0.01$, **$p < 0.05$, *$p < 0.1$.

Management implications. The relationship between CEOs' social media usage and corporate financing performance is a complex, cross-level phenomenon, influenced by both individual and organizational factors. According to upper echelons theory, the CEO plays a crucial role in shaping strategic decisions, with their personal characteristics, values, and experiences significantly influencing organizational outcomes. In the era of social media, a CEO's personal influence is amplified, creating strong tie relationships between the CEO and the company.

Despite the negative influence of CEOs' social media usage on financing performance, this can be mitigated by several factors: CEOs' promotion focus, the number of followers on social media, and the firm's B2C business model. This suggests that CEOs' social media influence can positively impact organizational outcomes, such as enhancing investor confidence, improving the corporate image, and increasing market recognition.

Table 8 LDA Topic Modeling.

	Topic 1		Topic 2		Topic 3		Topic 4
谢谢	thanks	葡萄酒	wine	红包	red envelope	小米	Xiaomi
酥饼	shortbread	葡萄	grape	馋嘴	glutton	私募	private placement
红包	red envelope	香槟	champagne	给力	awesome	中国	China
儿子	son	窗外	outside the window	鼓掌	applaud	公司	company
鄙视	despise	高春辉	Chunhui Gao	优酷	Youku	基金	fund
美拍	Mei Pai	泰国	Thailand	网易	NetEase	北京	Beijing
大人	grown ups	红葡萄酒	red wine	视频	video	感谢	grateful
此刻	now	越野	off-road	火鸟	firebird	净水器	water purifier
新年快乐	Happy New Year	早餐	breakfast	认证	certification	旅行	travel
中秋	Mid-autumn festival	意大利	Italy	宠物	pet	创业	start a business

For both companies and ceos, the study provides actionable strategies to optimize social media presence:

1. CEOs' Promotional Focus: Companies should encourage CEOs to leverage social media strategically, focusing on presenting a positive and authentic depiction of the company's growth, innovation, and achievements. CEOs should avoid entertainment-oriented content, which may reduce investor confidence.
2. Building Social Capital: CEOs should actively manage their personal brand on social media by posting business-related content, engaging with followers, and positioning themselves as thought leaders. This can enhance the company's credibility and attract investor interest.
3. Leveraging the B2C Business Model: For B2C firms, the negative influence of CEOs' social media usage on financing outcomes is less pronounced. These firms should use social media to humanize their brand by sharing customer stories, company impacts, and CEO insights, aligning with the direct consumer connection inherent in the B2C model.

Investors can also benefit from the study's findings by avoiding superficial judgments based on CEOs' social media content. Given the platform's entertainment-centric characteristics, investors should carefully assess the correlation between CEO personal traits and firm performance, using these insights to gauge potential investment risks and opportunities.

From a research perspective, the study offers actionable insights for guiding future corporate and investor behaviors:

1. Training for CEOs: Training programs should help CEOs understand the implications of their social media presence on investor relations and corporate financing. Such training should focus on crafting messages that align with strategic goals and meet investor expectations.
2. Social Media Strategy Development: Companies should develop a comprehensive social media strategy that includes CEOs' role in communicating corporate vision and financial performance. The strategy should balance CEOs' regulatory focus, the company's business model, and the target audience to ensure social media usage enhances financing efforts.
3. Performance Monitoring: Companies should monitor and assess the impact of CEOs' social media activity, tracking metrics such as engagement, sentiment, and follower growth. This allows for real-time adjustments to optimize social media's impact on financing outcomes.

While the study highlights the potential downsides of CEOs' social media usage, it does not suggest that companies should avoid social media altogether. Social media remains a powerful tool for building brand awareness, establishing consumer relationships, and conducting marketing campaigns. CEOs who have not yet engaged on social media should carefully evaluate the potential benefits and alignment with their company's brand strategy and target audience. Moreover, CEOs must recognize that managing social media effectively requires significant time and energy, which should not detract from their core management duties. CEOs should also be cautious about following industry trends or competitors without aligning with long-term strategic goals. Over-reliance on short-term social media traffic can lead to reputational risks, particularly when personal comments or actions result in negative public opinion.

Conclusions

To uncover the mechanisms through which CEOs' social media usage influences corporate financing performance, this study collects financing and Weibo usage data from a sample of 1438 companies that secured their first round of funding in 2015 and conducts empirical analysis. The results confirm the moderating roles of CEO regulatory focus, social capital, and business models on this relationship. Additionally, the research employs an LDA model to analyze the textual content of Weibo posts, thereby confirming the platform's tendency toward entertainment-oriented content.

The principal findings are as follows:

1. CEOs' social media usage negatively influences corporate financing performance.
2. This negative influence is attenuated for CEOs with a promotion focus.
3. The negative influence is mitigated as the number of followers increases.
4. The negative influence is weakened for firms with B2C business models.

These findings not only confirm the association between CEOs' social media activity and corporate financing outcomes but also extend existing theoretical frameworks.

According to Upper Echelons Theory, the CEO, as a key member of the top management team, possesses decision-making tendencies and behavioral patterns that significantly shape corporate strategy. This study suggests that CEOs' social media activities constitute part of these behavioral patterns and influence financing outcomes by promoting two-way interaction and real-time feedback.

Furthermore, the findings align with Regulatory Focus Theory, which distinguishes between two motivational orientations: promotion focus and prevention focus. CEOs with a promotion focus are more likely to project growth and innovation through social media, potentially offsetting negative investor perceptions typically associated with social media engagement.

The theoretical underpinnings are further supported by Field Theory, which posits that different social fields have distinct logics. The entertainment-oriented nature of social media may conflict with the formal, professional expectations of business and finance. When CEOs engage with social media in ways perceived as informal or inconsistent with professional norms, it may undermine their perceived authority, negatively influencing investor confidence.

In contrast, promotion-focused CEOs leverage social media to signal innovation, transparency, and growth. By posting business-related content more frequently, they enhance informational transparency, which builds investor trust and helps mitigate the adverse effects of social media usage. This behavior is consistent with Regulatory Focus Theory, which posits that individuals with a promotion focus adopt strategies aimed at maximizing gains and minimizing losses.

This study also contributes to the literature on social media and corporate performance. While prior research has largely examined firms' official social media accounts within capital markets, such content may be subject to impression management. In contrast, CEOs' personal social media accounts reflect their individual traits (Wang and Chen, 2020), which can meaningfully influence corporate decision-making. This creates a logical inference: "investors can observe CEO traits through personal social media usage, which may aid in predicting corporate outcomes and inform investment decisions." Accordingly, this study addresses a gap by examining how CEOs' social media behavior influences financing outcomes.

Limitations and future research

The generalizability of these findings is limited by the specific institutional context of China. Since the Sino-U.S. trade tensions

began in 2016, the business environment has become increasingly dynamic and uncertain. Future research should test the robustness of these findings in other emerging markets to assess external validity.

Second, relying solely on Sina Weibo data may not capture the full spectrum of social media engagement, especially given the multi-platform landscape in contemporary business communication. The study cannot ascertain whether the effects differ when CEOs use multiple platforms concurrently or whether different platform combinations yield varying influences on financing outcomes. Future studies could address this issue by incorporating cross-platform data.

Third, the influence of social media may vary across firms at different stages of the corporate life cycle, which this study does not explore. Additionally, no industry-specific restrictions were applied, which may limit interpretability. In some sectors, such as live-streaming e-commerce, CEO visibility and personal branding are critical to business success. For such firms, CEOs' social media presence may enhance rather than detract from corporate value. These contexts warrant further exploration to test the boundary conditions of the findings presented here.

Data availability

The data that support the findings of the study are available from Sina Weibo, but restrictions apply to the availability of these data, which were used under licence for the current study and so are not publicly available. The data are, however, available from the authors upon reasonable request and with the permission of Sina Weibo.

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Author contributions

Rui Zhang: conceptualization, data collection, methodology, writing - review & editing, supervision, project administration, funding acquisition. Menglin Cheng & Yifan Wang: writing - original draft, formal analysis. Mei Xue: language refinement and formatting adjustment on the original draft. All authors provided substantial feedback and revisions to the manuscript. All authors have read and agreed to the published version of the manuscript.

Competing interests

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Ethical approval

The article does not contain any studies with human participants performed by any of the authors.

Informed consent

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